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Humanity in the Hands of the Government

People are at the mercy of the society into which they are born. In the dystopian novel *Brave New World*, author Aldous Huxley reflects on his society and warns of a future where citizens are slaves to their government. Speaking through the protagonist, John the Savage, he implores his readers, “I come to bring you freedom, [...] do you like being slaves?” (Huxley 216-217). John originates from the Savage Reservation outside of the World State. The World State is a futuristic society in the year 632 After Ford. The World State uses a caste system led by ten highly ranked Alpha-Plus World Controllers. In order to guarantee pacificity, babies are decanted from embryos, limiting cognitive abilities to the roles in society that they will be prescribed. The World State uses special techniques to indoctrinate the children with its motto: “Community, Identity, and Stability.” In contrast, the Savages who live in protected outside areas are the only people who still give birth to babies and have family continuity. John was the first Savage to immigrate to the World State. He criticizes the ways of the World State, specifically how it deprives its citizens of freedom and individuality. Based on Huxley’s observations in his own society, he is warning his readers of his belief of an unpleasant truth that society’s trajectory is leading its people toward dehumanization, indoctrinated by a controlling government, and feeding a technocratic regime. Excessive government control will stifle the essence of what it means to be human.

The first example of the World State's dehumanization tactics is that it freely distributes rations of a recreational drug called soma. Under the influence of soma, the natural emotions people experience are curtailed and replaced with temporary dazed cheerfulness. The government of the World State employs soma as a form of social control, conditioning society with happiness and stability over freedom and authenticity. Social unrest is limited, and peace is maintained when citizens are in this induced state. This alarming form of dehumanization at the hands of the government does not go unnoticed by all characters. For example, when John looks at his mother on her deathbed, who is entirely high on soma, he implores her to "come back from this dream of ignoble pleasures [...] back into the significant, desperately important reality" (Huxley 209). John is one of the few realists in the World State, unencumbered by the effects of soma. He passionately argues that the government is controlling people through soma, taking authentic individuality and free-form thinking away from its people. As in *Brave New World*, Huxley may have felt he was watching something similar unfold in his 1920s experience in America. First, the American government ratified the 18th Amendment in 1920, limiting alcohol consumption. President Herbert Hoover described Prohibition as "a great social and economic experiment, noble in motive and far-reaching in purpose" (Lerner). It was a clear attempt at social control by the government. The "Noble Experiment" backfired; it hurt the economy and led to widespread civil disobedience and organized crime. Seeing the experiment fail, Huxley envisioned the government employing alcohol to take away freedom in a different way. Predictably, after *Brave New World* was published, the 21st Amendment repealed the 18th Amendment in 1933 ("Twenty-First Amendment"). However, the government did not simply repeal the ban; instead, it explicitly allowed the individual states to regulate alcohol, enabling the government to not only ration supplies but also to reap the benefits of additional tax revenues,

thereby further compounding the government's ability to control people in other ways with its additional financial resources. Huxley warned readers, albeit somewhat satirically, that real-life society will turn into a government-controlled quandary such as the World State.

Excessive government control also manifests through the deliberate erosion of humanity and natural selection by the World State's medical procedures. The Bokanovsky's Process purposely exposes decanted embryos to toxins, radiation, alcohol, and oxygen reduction to form numerous identical twins with limited capabilities, which are then assigned to lower castes and labeled as Gammas, Deltas, and Epsilons. Society incorporates this practice in order to prioritize quantity over quality. Purposefully creating disabilities across lower castes results in them behaving as machines to the economy. Their ability to experience a free childhood is denied, and they do not have the opportunity to educate themselves, choose a career path, and establish their own identity. Instead, the government controls how humans grow. In Huxley's era, various United States institutions, typically backed by government funding, pursued a similar endeavor known as eugenics: improving the genetic quality of the populace. For example, in 1927, the Supreme Court upheld the Virginia Sterilization Act of 1924, which allowed for the required sterilization of mentally unfit humans (Antonios). Also, the goal of the Eugenics Records Office was to collect biologically heritable traits from hundreds of thousands of people to pass laws that would restrict the liberties of undesirable citizens (Lawrence). *Brave New World* is an unsurprising byproduct of this milieu, a warning of what could come in the future. Additionally, hypnopaedic conditioning, the process of sleep teaching, is used by the government of the World State to control the public. While children sleep, they are forced to listen to devices that teach the morality of the World State, indoctrinating them into the world of contentedness and stability. Citizens live by these morals forever after. For example, World State citizen Lenina often

exclaims phrases such as “One cubic centimetre cures ten gloomy sentiments” (Huxley 99), referring to the guidance to take soma when unhappy. Ingraining these messages limits free thinking, as evidenced by characters such as Lenina. The World State does this to prevent a person from becoming free and unique and to ensure they do not rebel.

Lastly, the government gains control over the World State society by replacing family with technology. Citizens are mass-produced like vehicles on a Henry Ford assembly line, biologically slotted into a predestined role via the Bokanovsky Process. The citizens lack individuality; they lack a journey. However, as Lynn Hough wrote in 1920, “Life is a journey and not a destination; that the heart must be set upon those matters of character which are eternal and not upon those matters of sensation which pass away” (Hough 266). Huxley alerts the reader that society is drifting away from the journey, the truth, and toward happiness prescribed by fleeting sensations. The people in the World State depend on soma and sex to pass their lives by rather than discovering themselves through their unique journeys. Moreover, their existence revolves around serving the wheels of industry. Through indoctrination, they look up to the capitalist Ford as a god, and they are hypnopaedically conditioned to desire new goods incessantly. Huxley warns the readers that in the future, the idea of living will be based on conditioning consumers and producers, thereby feeding the economic engine. Compounding this lifeless environment, the World State government also abolishes families. Mothers and fathers typically provide social and emotional support but have been banished from the World State. True love is also rejected. John sees these problems, how they lack mothers, fathers, “wives, or children, or lovers to feel strongly about; they’re so conditioned that they practically can’t help behaving as they ought to behave. And if anything should go wrong, there’s soma” (Huxley 220). The people in the World State are stuck in a society where they are controlled not to develop relationships with one

another and not live a life as themselves. Huxley presents the persona that people should be careful with excessive technologies and indoctrination because people will become dehumanized in the future.

Inordinate government control will suppress individuality, freedom, and the essence of humanity. The World State government systematically brainwashes citizens into thinking that sex and soma will solve their disconcertment and then freely dispenses the drug to overtly facilitate the tranquilization of the people. Huxley sees in his own life the precursors of the danger of excessive government control, as he watched his government first ban alcohol and later unban it with regulations and taxes. Additionally, the World State government employed abusive medical procedures such as Bokanovsky's Process and hypnopaedia to physically and mentally shape its citizens without their consent. Again, Huxley saw warning signs in his own life, as eugenics was considered a progressive movement in that era. Finally, the World State government eliminates the role of personal relationships in favor of serving the state; even the roles of mothers, fathers, husbands, and wives, the core aspects of humanity, are not just minimized but viewed with abhorrence. While people rely on governments to protect and represent their interests, there lies an ever-present danger that powerful governments will overstep their bounds and covertly subjugate their citizens.

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